



A **WORKER** distributes ballots in vote-by-mail envelopes to be tallied at a processing site in City of Industry. GARY CORONADO For The Times

## Despite exodus, L.A. has housing crunch

Experts say household demographics and pent-up demand keep home prices high.

By JACK FLEMMING

The City of Angels lost nearly 10,000 residents last year. L.A. County lost 62,000. It's not exactly a mass exodus, but L.A.'s shrinking population is enough to leave a few economists shuddering at the long-term implications of so many people skipping town: less political influence, a smaller tax base, and more.

But amid the Southland's sea change, one thing seems to always stay the same: Housing is still expensive.

Typically, population declines and aging housing stock conjure visions of Rust Belt decay, where land loses value and abandoned homes sell for next to nothing. But in L.A. — despite vanishing Hollywood jobs and immigration crack-downs — housing costs remain sky-high.

This year, the region has seen a slight dip in home values and a slight uptick in vacancy rates. But L.A. County's population has been whittling down for the last decade, with 400,000 people leaving since 2016. During that stretch, home prices and rents have nearly doubled.

What gives? Experts say a few factors are at play, but there's one sneaky trend that's often overlooked: household composition.

"People are moving out of L.A., but households are becoming smaller, so the number of households that re-

[See **Homes**, A8]

## Park service advocates draw line at UFC fights

Some cry foul over events on D.C. public land

By Jack Dolan

President Trump plans to celebrate the nation's 250th anniversary — and his own 80th birthday — next month by watching bare-chested and bloody UFC fighters kick, punch and choke each other on the storied South Lawn of the White House.

Later, during the administration's summer-long festival to commemorate the signing of the Declaration of Independence, IndyCars will race in a fossil fuel-burning extravaganza around and around the National Mall — home to the U.S. Capitol and the Washington and Lincoln monuments.

Both venues are National Park Service land and are administered by the agency.

The planned spectacles — UFC Freedom 250 and the Freedom 250 Grand Prix — stray so far from the park service's traditional mission and ethos that advocates and career employees are crying foul.

"These events are inappropriate and disrespectful to the history and importance of the White House and the National Mall," said Jonathan Jarvis, who

began his career as a park ranger on the Mall in 1976 and was named director of the National Park Service by President Obama in 2009.

White House officials insist that IndyCar and the Ultimate Fighting Championship are extremely popular with everyday Americans: The race and the fights will be exuberant celebrations of patriotism and pride, they say.

The UFC event, in particular, "will be one of the greatest and most historic sports events in history, and President Trump hosting it at the White House is a testament to his vision to celebrate America's monumental 250th anniversary," said White House spokesperson Davis Ingle.

To organize this summer's events, the Trump administration asked the National Park Foundation — a congressionally chartered nonprofit that works closely with the park service and collects private donations to help maintain hiking trails and fund programs to get kids outdoors — to lend a hand.

Because of the scale of the planned

[See **Park**, A6]

## DWP calls for new police force

It says it needs its own armed officers to combat copper thefts

By Gavin J. Quinton



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

**COPPER THEFTS** are a leading cause of streetlight outages in Los Angeles, the mayor's office says.

For thieves looking to strip Los Angeles for parts, copper has become a fast-moving currency.

The problem has become so persistent that the Los Angeles Department of Water and Power is now asking for its own armed police force to protect vulnerable utility equipment, street lighting and critical infrastructure, insisting that the department's contracted and unarmed security guards aren't cutting it.

"They lack the authority to detain or arrest suspects, intervene in crimes in progress, conduct searches, or carry firearms for enforcement purposes," according to a May 21 report from the city agency. "Delays hinder timely intervention, reduce investigative effectiveness, and contribute to repeat vic-

[See **DWP**, A6]

## Becerra ahead in 3-way split in governor's race

Hilton and Steyer are in tight contest for No. 2 spot in top-two primary, poll shows.

By SEEMA MEHTA

On the cusp of California's gubernatorial June 2 primary, voters are closely divided among three candidates vying to succeed Gov. Gavin Newsom at a perilous moment in the state and nation's history, according to a poll released Friday.

Among likely California voters, 25% support Xavier Becerra, a Democrat and former Biden Cabinet secretary, according to the survey by UC Berkeley's Institute of Governmental Studies that was co-sponsored by the Los Angeles Times.

Republican Steve Hilton, a former Fox News commentator and British political strategist, has the backing of 21%, while 19% backed billionaire hedge fund founder turned environmental activist Tom Steyer, a Democrat.

The survey provided the clearest indication yet that the three have separated themselves from the rest of the field.

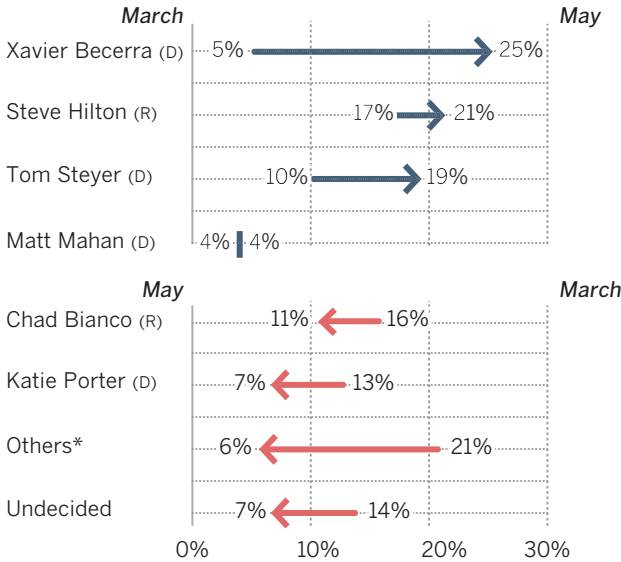
Support increased for Becerra, Hilton and Steyer since the last Berkeley IGS poll in March. Becerra leapfrogged everyone. In early March he wallowed near the bottom of the pack at just 5% support among likely voters, and now is the front-runner.

The other candidates floundered. Support for Riverside County Sheriff Chad Bianco, a Republican, [See **Gubernatorial**, A5]

### Becerra gained the most support in the last months

Likely voter preference for California governor

➔ Gained support since early March  
➔ Lost support



\*Early March results include 13% support for Eric Swalwell and 1% for Betty Yee, who have since dropped out of the race.

Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies poll conducted online May 19-24 in English and Spanish among 8,578 registered voters in California, 5,472 of whom were considered likely to vote in the primary. Results from the overall likely voter sample have an estimated sampling error of +/- 2 percentage points. Funding for the poll was provided in part by the Los Angeles Times.

LORENA INIGUEZ ELEBEE, HANNA SENDER Los Angeles Times

## Weiss shakes up CBS' crown jewel

Network chief fires executive producer of '60 Minutes' and two of its correspondents.

By STEPHEN BATTAGLIO

For 58 years, "60 Minutes" has been the untouchable crown jewel of American television news — a program that outlasted the rise of cable, the collapse of network ratings and every shift in the media landscape with its focus on serious, independent journalism.

On Thursday, CBS News Editor in Chief Bari Weiss shattered its glass case.

In the most sweeping

changes in the newsmagazine's nearly six-decade history, Weiss ousted the program's executive producer, Tanya Simon, and replaced her with Nick Bilton, 49, a veteran tech journalist and documentary filmmaker who worked for 13 years at the New York Times but who has no experience running a TV news operation.

Weiss also fired "60 Minutes" correspondents Sharyn Alfonsi, who clashed with her boss over a segment on President Trump's immigration policies, and Cecilia Vega, who left ABC News to join the program in 2023.

Bilton will be the first executive producer in the 58-year history of "60 Minutes" [See **'60 Minutes'**, A12]

## Mexicans in U.S. fear losing vital consulates targeted by Trump

By DORANY PINEDA AND MEGAN JANETSKY

Mexico's consulate in Los Angeles helps thousands of its citizens each week, assisting them with registering births, obtaining passports and, increasingly since President Trump's second term began, accessing legal help for loved ones who have fallen afoul of his administration's immigration policies.

The consulate serves the biggest Mexican community

in the United States. It and 52 other Mexican consulates in the country provide services that make Mexican people's lives easier — just as the nine U.S. consulates in Mexico improve the lives of Americans south of the border.

The U.S. State Department has launched a review that might lead to the closure of an unknown number of Mexican consulates. Although it hasn't said why, the review is happening against the backdrop of the immigration crackdown,

some thorny bilateral issues and far-right theories that the consulates have been interfering in U.S. politics and encouraging Mexicans to migrate northward.

Azucena Aviles, a 33-year-old mother who drove more than an hour to the L.A. consulate this month to renew her Mexican passport and get one for her daughter, said consular services are invaluable — especially in California, which is home to nearly 13 million people of Mexican descent, including

[See **Consulates**, A5]



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

### HARMONIOUS L.A. DAY

Gustavo Dudamel, left, embraces his successor as L.A. Phil music director, Daniel Harding, during a visit to Dodger Stadium. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

### DACA recipients mired in delays

Some are losing work permits and are exposed to deportation risk due to slowness of renewals. **NATION, A4**

### After O.C. crisis, a call for answers

Community leaders seek accountability from GKN Aerospace after mass evacuations. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

### Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 73/57. **B6**

